UNIT 5 USING BODY LANGUAGE EFFECTIVELY

Structure

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5.0 OBJECTIVES

This unit will help you to:

- Expand your vocabulary regarding non-verbal communication
- Understand non-verbal communication
- Recognize the importance of body language
- Improve your own body language
- Face an interview panel confidently
- Prepare and deliver a speech impressively

5.1 WARM UP

Look around you at the people in the room and identify:

- Body movements that indicate interest
- Body movements indicating boredom
- Signals exhibiting authority or power
- Movements that convey pride

Discuss the impact of these movements with a friend.

5.2 READING COMPREHENSION

Communication between people takes place in various ways. Most people think that the most popular way of communication is by speaking. What they don't know is that actual verbal communication, accounts for only 10% of a message. We really cannot determine the truthfulness or sincerity of people by what they say alone. Very often words transmitted verbally do not reflect what people really feel. The only way you can determine their true inner feelings is by reading their body language. It is difficult to question a person directly because even his/her replies may not indicate what s/he really feels or thinks. What then should we do?

Read people's body movements and gestures. Here are some examples of non verbal behaviour and their interpretation.

Brisk, erect walk	Confidence
Standing with hands on hips	Readiness, aggression
Sitting with legs crossed, foot kicking slightly	Boredom
Sitting, legs apart	Open, relaxed
Arms crossed on chest	Defensiveness
Walking with hands in pockets, shoulders hunched	Dejection
Hand on cheek	Evaluation, thinking
Touching, slightly rubbing nose	Rejection, doubt, lying
Rubbing the eye	Doubt, disbelief

Body Language during an Interview

When you appear for an interview it is important to remember that besides your resume you are going to be watched for the clothes that you wear and how you present yourself during the interview itself. After all before a word has even been spoken, your body language will have already given people their first impression of you. Based on your body language they would be able to assess if you come across as insecure or self assured. It can also show if you are an assertive or a quiet type of person. It helps give an impression whether you are speaking the truth or not. Body language can show if you are prone to stress or not. It can show others how enthusiastic you are and if you are a nice person, someone who will take work seriously and yet has a sense of humor. The Committee may ask you a question but they will pay attention not only to what you say but also to how you say it. Body Language will determine whether you "click". Everybody uses body language but it takes place mostly at the subconscious level. By becoming more aware of your own body language and recognizing the body language of others you can definitely improve and increase your chances of getting the job.



During your job interview, try to adopt a posture that shows interest but still comes across as being relaxed. You can do this by sitting up on the chair at the beginning of the interview with your back against your chair. If you slouch it might give the impression that you are not interested in the job. If you sit at the edge of a chair you come across as being tense and uncomfortable. You can change your body posture during the interview. For example, when someone says something, it is good to turn a little with your shoulders towards the speaker and to lean forward a little. This shows that you are taking interest in what the other person is saying. It is also important to pay attention to the posture of the person who is interviewing you.

Sometimes your hands are an obstacle during a job interview rather than a useful means of communication. In a difficult situation we fold our arms across our body. During a job interview it is better not to do this because it can be interpreted as a defensive gesture. It is better to let your hands lie on your lap or place them on the armrest of your chair. From these positions it is also easy to support your words with hand gestures. Hand movements also help to liven up the interview. It indicates that you feel at ease and you are relaxed. However, it is better not to make too many hand movements as it may be a distraction. Do pay attention to inadvertent movements that you may make sometimes due to nervousness. For example, shuffling your feet or kicking against the leg of a table can be very irritating to other people. Drumming with your fingers is also a distraction.



It is also important to show through your body language that you are listening to the people interviewing you. Looking directly into somebody's eyes or looking away actually serves as the dots and comas in your spoken sentences. When one of the committee members explains something or poses a question, keep looking at the person for as long as she / he is speaking. This shows that you are listening. When you answer a question you should look first at the person who asked the question, but while you answer you should take turns looking at the other people on the interview panel.

Success at the interview also comes from paying attention to the body language of the people interviewing you. Acceptance and irritation of the panel can be noted through their body language. So do be conscious of the body language of the members of the interview panel.

To conclude, do remember that knowledge of body language can help you in many ways to improve your own body language during an interview. Keep yourself updated on issues relating to body language to make a success of your career and your life.

Adapted from an article "Body Language during a Job Interview" by Frank van Mar Wijk.

Activity 1

1) Besides speaking what are the other means of communication?

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2) Here are some body gestures. What do you think they indicate?

- Sitting with hands clasped behind the head and crossing the legs

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- Open palms

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- Tilted head

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- Stroking chin

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3) What are some of the inherent qualities that your body language may reveal at an interview? List at least four.

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4) What advice does the article give you regarding sitting on the chair at an interview.

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5) Some movements could be distracting and irritating. What are they?

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6) Mention two other points to remember about body language when facing an interview panel.

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5.3 VOCABULARY: MAKING SENTENCES

Activity 2

1) Use the following words in sentences so as to bring out their meaning.

i) convey

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ii) transmit

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iii) assess

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iv) self-assured

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v) prone

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vi) indicate

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vii) inadvertently

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viii) mutual

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ix) updated

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x) issues

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5.4 LISTENING COMPREHENSION

Activity 3

After listening to the audio, attempt these questions.

1) Complete these sentences:

i) If you understand body language you can excel in your ……and……

ii) Dialogue includes ……

iii) Before we reach any conclusion we must understand ……

iv) Understanding the unspoken word have helped people ……..

v) One should not just believe the …….

2) Match the gestures in A with what they indicate in B.

i)	Left hand over right with palms down shows	disinterest
ii)	Right hand over left shows	interest
iii)	Crossing legs watching without flickering the eyes shows	encouragement
iv)	Nodding the head shows	decision making
v)	Narrowing of the eyes and stroking the chin shows	disagreement

5.5 SPEAKING: A TELEVISION INTERVIEW

Activity 4

Mr. Jaiswal is the CEO of a well known advertising firm. Ms. Bindu is a TV reporter. In pairs, take on the roles of Mr. Jaiswal and Ms. Bindu and practise the interview. Listen to the dialogue to get the right stress and intonation.

Ms. Bindu: Good evening viewers. Welcome to the Business Show. We have with us a very important guest this evening. It is none other than Mr. Jaiswal, CEO of Ogilcy and Ogilcy – the well known advertising firm. Good evening Mr. Jaiswal, let me begin by thanking you for spending time with us. Could you tell our viewers when you started this firm? Tell us something about the origin of the organization?

Mr. Jaiswal: Well, it all began in a very small way, when my brother and I decided to set up a printing press. We did our work well and we began to get orders to print advertisements. That was the beginning. It was printing advertisements, and not creating advertisements that started us off.

Ms. Bindu: That is interesting. So what made you enter the world of advertising?

Mr. Jaiswal: We started getting involved in what we printed. Then we wondered why should we not design the advertisements? I still remember that it was an advertisement for biscuits. Something simple yet something that reached every home. That advertisement was a success. It really reached out.

Ms. Bindu: That's great! But today we see you as the head of a firm that is synonymous with everything in advertising whether it is in the print or visual media. How did that happen?

Mr. Jaiswal: Well it just happened. We got a good creative team together and we set up an advertising firm. Perhaps it was the team headed by Mr. Tiwari that really stole the show. The people just loved it and there was no turning back.

Ms. Bindu: Viewers let us take a quick break and watch two popular advertisements designed by Mr. Jaiswal.

Ms. Bindu: Wasn't that really spellbinding? All of us really love watching those advertisements over and over again. Mr. Jaiswal, yours is really a success story. Since we are running short of time, would you like to give our viewers a special message?

Mr. Jaiswal: Yes, ours is a success story but success does not come without effort. Hard work, originality, good team work and a desire to do your best will really go a long way to make you the No. 1 company.

Ms. Bindu: That's a wonderful message for all of us wherever we are, whatever we do. Thank you Mr. Jaiswal and thank you viewers. See you again on our Business Show next week.

5.6 GRAMMAR: 'IF' – CONDITIONAL CLAUSES

1) Eg. (1) Teo has lost his watch. He thinks it might be in Lin's house.

   So he says. 'If I find my watch in Lin's house I will give you a call'

   (There is a strong possibility that he will find the watch)

2) Eg. (2) Ayesha imagines what she will do if she wins a lottery

   "If I won a lottery, I would give it to charity"

   (Here Ayesha is imagining the possibility of winning a lottery, she does not believe in that possibility)

   In sentence 1 we are referring to an action or event that will be possible or is likely to happen. Therefore, we promise something. In such cases we use the simple present tense in the 'if' clause and simple future in the main clause.

   In sentence 2, we are referring to an action or event that is imaginary or impossible. In such cases we use the simple past tense in the *if clause*, and *would* plus *the first form of the verb* in the main clause.

   Also remember that if the 'if' clause comes before the main clause, it is followed by a comma. If the main clause comes before the 'if' clause, we don't put comma before the 'if' clause.

   Here are some more examples of the use of 'If' conditional clauses.

3) I'd be very frightened if a thief entered my home.

4) If I go to France this summer, I will visit all the museums.

5) If you asked me out for dinner I'd order a vegetarian meal.

6) If you loved me you would not do this to me.

7) We would all be very ill if we drank the water from that tank.

1) Complete these sentences using main or if clauses.

   i) If I went to bed now, _____

   ii) _____ if we did not accept their invitation.

   iii) If I was bitten by a snake, _____

   iv) What would you do if _____?

   v) What would happen if _____?

2) Put the verb in brackets in the correct form.

   i) I'm sure she will lend you the money. I'd be very surprised if she _____ . (refuse)

   ii) If somebody _____ in here with a gun, I'd be very frightened. (walk)

   iii) I'm sure Ibrahim _____ if you explained the situation to him. (understand)

   iv) Nimi gave me this ring. She _____ very upset if I lost it. (be)

   v) _____ you mind if I used the phone? (will)

   vi) If he finishes his work on time, I _____(take) him out for lunch.

   vii) The litmus paper turns red if we _____ (dip) it in acid.

   viii) I'll punish him if he always _____ (come) home late.

   ix) If you drink dirty water, you _____ (fall) sick.

   x) The prices _____ (go up) if it does not rain well.

3) Answer the questions in the example given below:

   Example:

   a) Shall we leave at 10.30 am?

   b) No (arrive / too early) If we leave at 10.30 a.m. we will arrive too early.

   i) Is Lyn going to write the examination?

   No. (fail) If she _____

   ii) Let's be honest with them.

   No. (not believe) If _____

   iii) Why don't we visit Birmingham?

   No (cost too much) If _____

   iv) Is Manju going to apply for the job?

   No (not get) If_____

   v) Why don't we invite Jay home?

   No. (have to invite friends too) If_____

5.7 WRITING: A SPEECH

Activity 6

You have been asked to give a speech to a group of young people in your community on "posture". Here are a few points. Using them write out a speech to be delivered at the community center.

- Posture shows level of self confidence
- Attentiveness when body turns to the speaker
- Lack of interest and reservation shown when you do not incline towards the speaker
- Hunch shoulders and lowered head indicates a tendency to hide and not be seen
- A puffed chest shows aggressiveness
- Posture shows your status in the group

Remember to use simple, conversational language that will help to establish a rapport with the audience.

5.8 LET US SUM UP

Interpersonal relations play a major part in our lives today. Yet relationships are built on so many things that are left unsaid. In this unit you have learnt about the significance of body language. This will help you to understand people and make you conscious of your own body. You have also been introduced to a large number of words (both adjectives and verbs) associated with body language. Besides, you have practised preparing and giving a speech. Someday, when you sit as a member of the interview panel this knowledge will help you in performing your role as an interviewer.

5.9 ANSWERS

Activity 1

1) The other means of communicating are by observing and understanding body movements.

2)
- Confidence, Superiority
- Trust, sincerity, innocence
- Interest
- Process of taking a decision

3) Whether you are insecure
speaking the truth
prone to stress
you are enthusiastic
you have a sense of humour
(any four)

4) Have your back against the chair
Do not slouch on the chair
Do not sit on the edge of the chair
Change body postures to face other interviewers

5) Too many movements of the hands
Shuffling of the feet
Kicking the table
Drumming your fingers

6) Look at the person who poses the questions initially. Look at everyone else thereafter.

Activity 2

1) His letter does not convey his true feeling about the incident.
2) We can use a radio to transmit messages.
3) His mode of living makes it difficult to assess his status.
4) His way of walking indicates that he is a self assured person.
5) She is always prone to accidents, so I am not surprised.
6) All the symptoms indicate that Ravinder has dengue fever.
7) The secret just slipped out from my mouth inadvertently.
8) The respect between the two department heads is mutual.
9) This letter will keep you updated about the events.
10) I have no issues to settle with you so please be relaxed.

Audio text: Body Language and the Art of Listening through one's eyes: Magic of Movements

It's no myth that those who understand body language better excel in their workplace and in their social circle because they know when to make the right moves. Managers, salespersons, teachers and many more use it in their everyday life to their advantage.

The way we speak and what we speak forms a very small portion of our dialogue. The majority of the conversation can be understood through a person's body language. An experienced salesperson always looks into the eyes of his customer to see his pupils. If the pupils are dilated then it means that the customer is interested in the product and that it is the right time to strike.

During a meeting or training program or a presentation you can very easily make out if a person is listening to you or not. If the left hand is kept on right hand and the palms facing down then it's a clear cut signal that the listener is interested in whatever you are saying. On the other hand, if the right one covers the left one it's a signal of disagreement or that the listener wants to raise a point opposing yours. If a person is sitting with his arms and legs crossed and gazing continuously at you without flickering his eyes then it means that the person is not interested in what you are talking about. If a listener nods his head then it means that he is interested and is encouraging you. On the other hand, if he nods his head rapidly then it means that he wants you to finish quickly. If the listener narrows his eyes

occasionally or strokes his chin or pulls his beard gently then it's a sign of evaluation and that the listener is about to make a decision.

However, all said and done, one must be wise enough to read the overall signals and not come to any conclusion based on just any one gesture. It is the art of understanding the unspoken words that has given an edge to those who have excelled in their respective professions merely over others who believed the word of mouth.

Activity 3

1)

i) excel in your workplace and social circle.

ii) the way we speak and what we speak.

iii) all the overall signals.

iv) excel in their professions.

v) spoken word.

2)

i)	Left hand over right with palms down show	interest
ii)	right hand over left shows	disagreement
iii)	crossing legs, watching without flickering the eyes shows	disinterest
iv)	nodding the head shows	encouragement
v)	narrowing of the eyes and stroking the chin shows	decision making

Activity 5

1)

i) I would wake up early in the morning.

ii) They would feel bad ————

iii) ———— I would see a doctor at once.

iv) ————someone hurt you?

v) ———— you won the lottery?

Accept all ideas as long as the correct form of the verb is used.

2)

i) refused

ii) walked

iii) would understand

iv) would be

v) would

vi) will take

vii) dip

viii) comes

ix) will fall

x) will go up

3)

i) If she wrote it, she would fail

ii) If we are honest with them they will still not believe us/ If we were honest with them they would not believe us.

iii) If we visited Birmingham it would cost too much/If we visit Birmingham, it will cost too much.

iv) No, if she applied for the job she would not get it/If she applies for the job, she will not get it.

v) No, if we invited Jay we would have to invite his friends too. / No if we invite Jay we will have to invite his friends too.

Activity 6

Friends, we are all aware that communication can be both verbal and non verbal. I am going to tell you something about non-verbal communication which is sometimes more potent and effective than a hundred spoken words. I will take just one aspect of non-verbal communication and that is your posture. Have you ever wondered about what your posture conveys? It really tells the person watching a lot about you. It conveys the level of your self confidence. By orienting your body to a speaker addressing you, you show attentiveness and by not doing it you show lack of interest and reservation. It may also indicate indifference. As you listen to the speaker your alertness is indicated by the way you sit. Hunched shoulders and head down indicates a tendency to hide and not be seen.

It could even show dishonesty. Of course, puffing your chest up and placing your head with your chin up could be a sign of superiority or over confidence. You may appear as a rather unpleasant person. Above all your posture reveals your status within the group. So friends do take care of your posture and do remember that even if you have not spoken a word people can learn a lot about you just by observing your posture. It speaks a lot about you!